

Can Generative Artificial Intelligence Productivity Tools Support Workplace Learning?

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**Can Generative Artificial Intelligence Productivity Tools
Support Workplace Learning? A Qualitative Study on
Employee Perceptions in a Multinational Corporation**

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Can Generative Artificial Intelligence Productivity Tools Support Workplace Learning? A Qualitative Study on Employee Perceptions in a Multinational Corporation

Abstract

Purpose

The purpose of this study was to explore employees' perceptions and firsthand experiences of the impact of generative AI productivity tools, specifically Microsoft 365 Copilot, on individual and collective learning processes within a multinational corporation. In doing so, the study provides insights into how these tools can shape workplace learning dynamics, fostering both individual skill development and collaborative knowledge-sharing practices.

Design/methodology/approach

We collected responses from 357 participants through a survey that included both multiple-choice and open-ended questions. This study focuses exclusively on the qualitative responses. The reflexive thematic analysis method was employed to capture and interpret employees' perceptions of the role of Microsoft 365 Copilot—a generative AI-powered assistant integrated into the Microsoft 365 suite of applications (e.g. Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams) —in enhancing their work and learning opportunities in the workplace.

Results

The results highlight four key themes contributing to workplace learning. At the individual level, *Task Support* illustrates the extent to which generative AI productivity tools transform work practices and facilitate both formal and informal learning pathways, while *Meaningful Work* underscores the tools' role in enhancing employees' foundational knowledge through enriched information. At the organisational level, *Organisational Culture* suggests the importance of fostering a supportive environment for AI integration, while *Organisational Socialisation* highlights its influence on team cohesion and the informal knowledge-sharing processes essential for effective collaboration within and among team members.

Originality

This study shifts the narrative around the role of AI in the workplace by examining how generative AI productivity tools can enhance workplace learning at both individual and organisational levels, rather than focusing solely on their potential to disrupt work through displacement and automation.

By positioning AI-based applications as complementary to human work, this approach highlights their potential as enablers of skill development, knowledge sharing, and job enrichment, fostering a more adaptive and learning-oriented work environment.

Practical implications

The results of this study offer actionable insights for organisations integrating generative AI productivity tools in the workplace. Understanding employees' perceptions of the role of AI in workplace learning can inform the design of targeted training programmes that promote individual skill development and foster collaborative knowledge sharing. Furthermore, a supportive organisational culture that positions AI as a complementary resource can improve employee engagement, reduce resistance to new technologies, and encourage a growth-oriented mindset, ultimately driving both personal and organisational development.

Keywords

organisational socialisation, meaningful work, formal and informal learning, incidental learning, sociotechnical capital

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Can Generative Artificial Intelligence Productivity Tools Support Workplace Learning? A Qualitative Study on Employee Perceptions in a Multinational Corporation

1. Introduction

Work as we know it is changing—and rapidly. This shift is largely driven by smart technologies, with artificial intelligence (AI) at the forefront (Ernst et al., 2019; Howard, 2019). AI-driven applications are now ubiquitous across both manufacturing and service sectors, fundamentally *altering the social fabric of work itself* (Selenko et al., 2022), and *redefining—if not replacing—traditional roles* (Kolade & Owoseni, 2022; Leon, 2023; Rony et al., 2024).

At the organisational level, AI is challenging the social fabric of work by reshaping workplace structures (e.g. how work is organised and how organisational structure hierarchies are configured) and redefining the dynamics of workplace relationships (e.g. affecting how individuals connect, communicate, and collaborate) (Selenko et al., 2022). For instance, in the media sectors, leading media outlets are leveraging generative artificial intelligence (gen-AI) to generate full articles covering diverse topics such as politics, global affairs, financial markets, entertainment, sports, and crime (Corvello, 2025; Mariani & Dwivedi, 2024). In the manufacturing sector, AI is enabling faster, data-driven decision-making and real-time workflow optimisation (Cao et al., 2021). This transformation also challenges traditional decision-making, pushing the boundaries of human-AI collaboration and requiring orchestration of complex decision processes between humans and AI-based systems (Jarrahi, 2018; Soori et al., 2024). Additionally, it raises ethical concerns regarding traceability, responsibility, and accountability, particularly when used in healthcare to assist in diagnosing diseases, analysing medical images, and suggesting treatment plans (Corvello, 2025). Organisations play a critical role in shaping the approach to AI adoption and integration; therefore, a supportive organisational culture can support openness to learning and adaptability, enabling employees to feel encouraged and equipped to develop new skills and embrace AI-driven workflows (Martínez-Caro et al., 2020).

At the individual level, AI is taking over tasks that were once the domain of humans, particularly repetitive or data-intensive tasks. For instance, gen-AI tools now handle data entry, basic customer inquiries through chatbots, and even elements of report generation (e.g. (Casheekar et al., 2024; Kumar et al., 2024; Leitner-Hanetseder & Lehner, 2022). As AI automates these activities, employees

are increasingly required to develop new skills to work effectively alongside these systems (Colbert et al., 2016; Singh & Tarkar, 2022), and adapting to new roles (Kipper et al., 2021). Additionally, as AI complements, replaces, or creates new tasks, these shifts redefine what it means to work collaboratively (i.e. with peer and smart technologies), and, therefore, alter the roles individuals play within the workplace, fundamentally impacting organisational socialisation (Chowdhury et al., 2022).

Organisational socialisation refers to the processes through which employees adapt to, integrate within, derive identity and develop a sense of belonging from their organisational roles and social networks (Feldman, 1981; Myers, 2010). In hybrid human-AI environments, work relationships evolve as employees interact with gen-AI tools as a form of *digital colleague* (Khoreva & Einola, 2024; Wilson & Daugherty, 2018), which modifies traditional team dynamics and challenges the way knowledge is shared and developed within the workplace. New approaches to team collaboration, communication, and trust-building become essential, where digital tools not only support human work but also can influence the ongoing learning and development process, nurturing both formal and informal knowledge exchange (Bankins & Formosa, 2023; Santoni de Sio et al., 2024). This transformation also reshapes workplace learning, as employees need to continuously adapt and build new skills to collaborate effectively with AI (Kolade & Owoseni, 2022; Leon, 2023).

With AI altering the content of work, there is an emerging focus on the purpose and value of human contributions. The concept of meaningful work, a core component of the Job Characteristics Model (JCM) by Hackman and Oldham (Hackman & Oldham, 1975, 1976), is well established in work design literature and is closely linked to the perception of task significance—the feeling that one's work positively impacts others (Martela & Pessi, 2018; Tommasi et al., 2024). Meaningful work contributes to employees' identity and self-actualisation, fostering motivation, engagement, and retention, particularly for experienced employees who seek fulfilment and a sense of ownership in their roles (Hackman et al., 2015; Martela & Pessi, 2018). Additionally, meaningful work impacts how employees engage with learning, as the sense of purpose and relevance encourages them to adopt deeper, more proactive approaches to developing new skills and adapting to changes in their roles (Bailey et al., 2018).

Despite the rapid integration of AI tools into workplace practices, there is still limited understanding of how employees perceive these technologies as enablers of workplace learning and collaboration. This gap in knowledge poses challenges for organisations in creating supportive environments that can foster effective learning, skill development, and collaboration between employees and AI systems. Furthermore, the lack of insights into these dynamics can hinder the development of strategies to address the cultural and structural changes required for successful AI adoption.

Understanding how these factors and dynamics at both organisational and individual levels transform employee experiences with AI tools is essential for identifying opportunities to enhance learning and collaboration in future AI-supported environments.

This study focused on exploring the views of employees in a multinational corporation regarding the perceived learning opportunities and enablers associated with their interactions with Microsoft 365 Copilot—a generative AI-powered productivity tool that utilises large language models (LLMs) to generate text, analyse data, create presentations, and deliver generated responses to user prompts, offering a new form of interactive work aid in the workplace (Khan, 2024). The research was guided by the following questions:

- How do employees perceive the role of Microsoft 365 Copilot in transforming their daily work practices?
- To what extent does the use of Copilot support learning and knowledge-sharing among employees?

To investigate these questions, we conducted an online survey with open-ended questions to gather employees’ perceptions and insights into the extent to which Microsoft 365 Copilot is transforming their daily work and, more critically, on whether its use and application foster a positive impact on learning and knowledge sharing.

2. Theoretical and research underpinnings

2.1 Application of generative AI-powered productivity tools in organisations

Generative AI-powered tools represent a transformative shift in workplace practices, particularly in the context of productivity and organisational learning. These tools aim to enable enhanced collaboration, facilitate decision-making processes, and reduce cognitive overload by automating routine or repetitive tasks (Chowdhury et al., 2022; Makarius et al., 2020). This integration aims to enable employees to save time on routine tasks, with the goal of reallocating their efforts to more creative and strategic activities, thereby fostering a culture of continuous learning and adaptation (Noe et al., 2014).

Studies highlight that AI-powered tools, such as gen-AI, not only augment human effort but also create new paradigms for informal learning in the workplace (Guan et al., 2024; Liu & Ma, 2024). Critically, these technologies support real-time problem-solving, adaptive feedback mechanisms, and seamless knowledge sharing among employees, resulting in a hybrid learning ecosystem that can integrate formal and informal processes (Noe et al., 2014; Tynjälä, 2008). Informal or incidental learning (Karhapää et al., 2024; Lokhtina & Faller, 2024), which accounts for a significant proportion

of workplace learning, thrives in this environment, enabling employees to acquire context-specific skills and insights through experiential engagement and iterative practices (Park & Lee, 2018; Watkins et al., 2018). Moreover, these tools can contribute to the development of human capital by facilitating self-regulated learning, where individuals actively manage their learning trajectories based on immediate task demands and long-term professional goals (Makarius et al., 2020). This aligns with the broader organisational need to remain agile and competitive in a rapidly evolving global economy (Chowdhury et al., 2022). Gen-AI tools, therefore, are not merely productivity enhancers but can be enablers of workplace innovation, continuous learning, and human-AI collaboration (Sharma & Bozkurt, 2024).

The implementation of AI-powered tools in contexts involving knowledge workers—whose primary responsibilities focus on mental processes such as analysis, reasoning, problem-solving, decision-making, or creativity, and who rely on their knowledge, expertise, and intellectual capabilities, often requiring specialised skills, critical thinking, and adaptability (Abbasi & Bordia, 2019)—raises several problematic aspects that warrant careful consideration. The ethical challenges surrounding AI implementation are particularly pressing (Coeckelbergh, 2019; Floridi, 2023). Concerns about data privacy and security, transparency, accountability, responsibility, and bias are crucial when integrating these tools into organisational processes designed to augment human capabilities and automate certain tasks (Callari et al., 2024; Rezaei et al., 2024). Indeed, AI-based systems may inadvertently reinforce biases present in their training data, and accountability, where it may be unclear who is responsible for decisions made or actions taken by AI tools (Coeckelbergh, 2022; Rezaei et al., 2024; Santoni de Sio & Mecacci, 2021). The lack of transparency in AI decision-making processes further complicates these challenges, as employees and organisations may find it difficult to understand how AI systems arrive at specific recommendations or outcomes (Baltrusch et al., 2022; Weber et al., 2023). One significant concern is the potential dependency on AI systems, where employees may become overly reliant on these tools to perform their tasks, diminishing their critical thinking and problem-solving capabilities over time (Floridi, 2023; Glikson & Woolley, 2020), with reduced human agency and autonomy (Floridi, 2023; Santoni de Sio, 2024). This dependency can reduce employees' ability to operate independently and may create vulnerabilities if the AI system fails or produces inaccurate outputs.

Finally, in the context of workplace learning, employee deskilling resulting from the automation of routine or complex cognitive tasks remains a significant concern. As AI systems increasingly take over cognitive functions traditionally performed by humans, such as text generation, data analysis, content summarisation, and decision-making support, there is a risk that employees may lose

opportunities to practise and develop these skills, potentially exacerbating the skills gap within the workforce (Vallor, 2015, 2024).

2.2 Sociotechnical capital and its implications for workplace learning

The theoretical lens applied in this study frames AI not as a disruptive technology with solely negative impacts on jobs and work dynamics, but rather as a constructive tool that, when strategically adopted, can enhance individual performance, self-development, and organisational outcomes (Chowdhury et al., 2022; Fleming, 2019). From this perspective, AI-based applications can enable employees to offload dull or repetitive tasks, allowing them to focus on more engaging, skill-enriching activities that foster workplace learning and professional growth (Makarius et al., 2020). Arguably, recent research has underscored the extent to which AI-based technologies are increasingly becoming a new dimension to the learning landscape, playing a transformative role in learning and development within organisations (Bennett & McWhorter, 2022; Li & Yeo, 2024). To this end, the sociotechnical capital framework (Makarius et al., 2020) refers to the competitive advantage gained from the effective collaboration between people and AI-based technology within an organisation. Critically, this approach highlights that achieving optimal human-AI interaction and integration necessitates a balance between human and technological elements, promoting an environment where both contribute uniquely to competitive advantage and sustained value creation (Chowdhury et al., 2022).

3. Methods

3.1 Setting

This study was conducted within a global manufacturing corporation headquartered in Europe, employing approximately 40,000 people. While AI systems have long been utilised in technical domains such as product development, manufacturing, and maintenance, the recent advancements in LLMs have broadened their application across the entire company, spanning various functional areas and roles. Digitalisation now forms the cornerstone of the company's strategy, with gen-AI systems playing a significant role. This has led to the launch of several initiatives aimed at identifying and implementing AI applications in diverse areas, including engineering, product development, customer support, manufacturing, and supply chain management. These initiatives focus primarily on identifying tasks and knowledge areas where gen-AI can have the greatest impact, alongside developing tools to support its integration. As part of a recent initiative, the company introduced Microsoft 365 Copilot to its white-collar workforce. The organisation allocated Microsoft licences to a targeted group of 802 employees globally, without implementing a formal change management

programme. This approach offered a unique opportunity to investigate how employees utilised to the tool in their daily work routines.

Microsoft 365 Copilot is integrated into the Microsoft 365 suite of applications, including Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams. For example, in Word, Copilot can draft, rewrite, or summarise lengthy documents; in Excel, it can generate pivot tables, create visual charts; in PowerPoint, Copilot can assist users by generating complete slide decks from simple outlines, including designing visual elements and crafting speaker notes. Finally, in Outlook, it summarises long email threads, drafts replies, and prioritises urgent messages; while in Teams, Copilot facilitates collaboration by summarising meeting discussions, suggesting action points, and even creating follow-up task lists based on meeting outcomes.

However, growing awareness—driven by both user feedback and testimonials from other organisations—has prompted the company to consider the psychological and ethical implications of adopting Microsoft 365 Copilot. These reflections have been incorporated into a broader initiative called “Future of Work”. It is within the framework of this initiative that the current study was launched.

3.2 Procedure

A survey was developed to explore employees’ perceptions of Microsoft 365 Copilot and its influence on their productivity, work practices, and learning experiences. The survey consisted of both multiple-choice and open-ended questions; for this study, we focus specifically on the responses to the open-ended questions. Qualitative surveys can provide a ‘wide-angle lens’ on the phenomenon under investigation (Braun et al., 2021), by offering the potential to capture a diversity of perspectives, experiences, and interpretations, which is particularly valuable when investigating a relatively unexplored or understudied area, as in the present study.

In July and August 2024, the survey was distributed to 802 participants across the organisation’s various departments globally, all of whom had been provided with a Copilot licence for use in their daily work. The open-ended questions were designed to address aspects closely related to workplace learning, including the tool’s influence on specific tasks, perceived usefulness, and opportunities for skill enhancement. Additionally, the questions explored broader aspects, such as team collaboration and the organisational culture surrounding the adoption of gen-AI productivity tools, which are key factors in the learning environment within workplaces. Questions included:

- *“What specific tasks is Microsoft 365 Copilot assisting you with in your work?”* – This question was designed to reveal how employees discover new areas of support offered by the tool, which could foster incidental learning.
- *“Why and how do you think the implementation of Microsoft 365 Copilot could impact meaningful work?”* – This question was designed to explore employees' reflections on how the tool may change their work and learning processes, encouraging them to consider potential shifts in skill application and learning approaches.
- *“How do you experience the organisational culture regarding the adoption and use of Microsoft 365 Copilot?”* – Organisational culture plays a vital role in workplace learning. This question was designed to provide insights into the environment in which employees learn to use and adapt to the Gen-AI, highlighting support structures and potential challenges to adopting these tools as part of their learning landscape.
- *“How do you feel the use of Microsoft 365 Copilot impacts team collaboration and social interactions?”* – This question was designed to understand how employees perceive the effects of Gen-AI productivity tools on team dynamics, and the extent to which social learning and informal knowledge-sharing might be affected—both crucial elements of workplace learning.

3.3 Sample

Out of N=802 invited participants, N=357 responded to the survey. This sample is consistent with the demographics of the organisation's overall workforce and aligns with broader population trends observed within the industry.

Regarding the gender distribution of the sample, (N=240) 67% of respondents identified as men, (N=110) 31% as women, while 2% preferred not to disclose their gender. The sample is primarily composed of participants aged 35–44 and 45–54, with 134 respondents (37.5%) in each group, followed by 44 participants aged 55–64, 42 aged 25–34, and smaller numbers in the under-25 (1) and over-64 (2) age categories. In terms of qualifications, almost half of the sample (49.6% equal to N=177 respondents) have obtained a Master’s degree, followed by 96 respondents with a Bachelor's degree (26.9%), 19 (5.3%) with a High School diploma, 11 (3.1%) with an Associate degree, and 3 (0.9%) with vocational training. Higher qualifications include Doctoral degrees (5% equal to N=18 respondents) and MBAs (7% equal to N=25 respondents). The average seniority of the sample is 13.3 years within the company. Finally, the sample demonstrates varying levels of remote work participation. A total of 63 participants reported no remote work (0%), while 114 work remotely 20% of the time (one day per week), 105 at 40% of the time (two days per week), 33 at 60% of the time (three days per week), 21 at 80% (four days per week), and 21 work fully remotely (100%).

3.4 Analysis

The qualitative responses were uploaded into an NVivo project and analysed thematically to capture employees' perspectives on how gen-AI tools like Microsoft 365 Copilot can either support or challenge learning within the workplace. Initially, all responses were treated as a single unit of analysis. Following Braun and Clarke's approach to thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022a, 2022b), codes were inductively derived around the phenomenon under investigation. This inductive approach was chosen to ensure that we captured all meanings, perspectives, and nuances expressed by respondents, without being constrained by any a priori assumptions or categories.

Once the initial coding was complete, the codes were grouped into the four primary thematic areas corresponding to the key aspects explored for this paper: *Task Support*, *Meaningful Work*, *Organisational Culture*, and *Organisational Socialisation*. This allowed for a structured analysis while maintaining the flexibility to encompass emergent patterns beyond these predefined themes. The analysis was conducted by both authors, one of whom is an employee of the company, providing insights and nuances into the organisational culture that informed further the interpretation of the data and results.

4. Results and discussion

The following results reflect employees' perceptions of how workplace learning is supported through Microsoft 365 Copilot at both individual and organisational levels, across four key themes: task support, meaningful work, organisational culture, and socialisation (Figure 1).

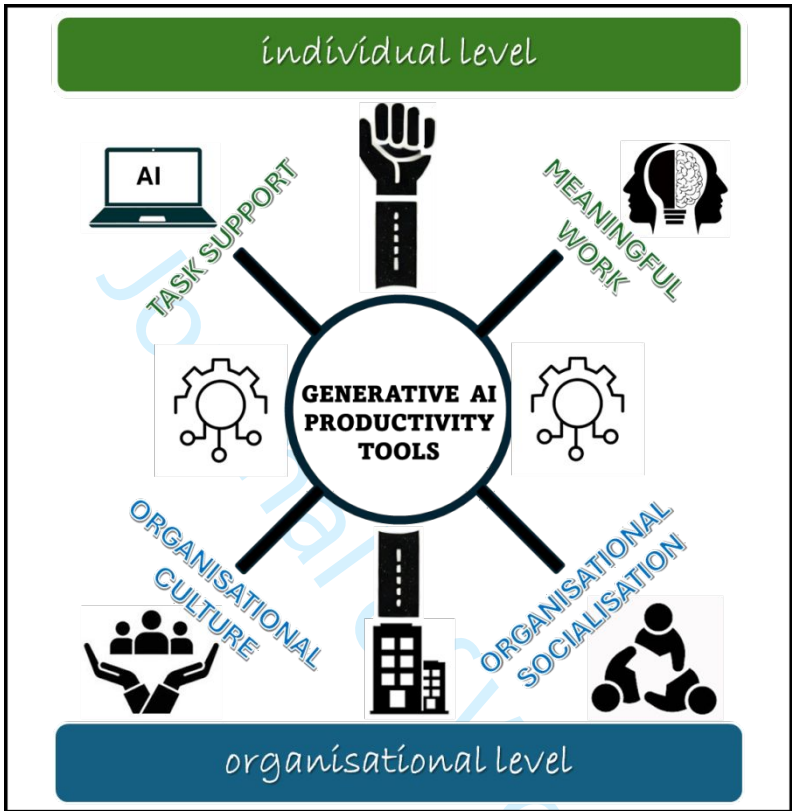


Figure 1: Workplace learning through Microsoft 365 Copilot spans individual and organisational levels across four themes (Source: Authors own work).

4.1 Considerations in task support

“My productivity is enhanced and the time spent on routine tasks is reduced. Copilot provides me also opportunity to innovate for example in content creation, and to be more accurate/faster when I write emails (editing for me).”

Microsoft 365 Copilot primarily assists employees with tasks that benefit from automation, efficiency, and structured outputs. All respondents confirm that Copilot supports activities such as administrative tasks (such as taking minutes, summarising meeting notes, etc.) and basic document support (such as drafting communications, generating presentations, and facilitating data-driven insights) with a perceived positive impact on efficiency and timesaving. These tasks require minimal oversight, such as verifying output accuracy or making small adjustments, which aligns well with familiar workflows and reduces the cognitive effort typically involved in completing these tasks manually.

Prompting has proven to be crucial for effective interaction with gen-AI productivity tools, as it requires users to formulate clear and effective inputs and queries that directly influence the relevance, accuracy, and quality of the AI's outputs to meet users' specific task requirements (Sundberg & Holmström, 2024). Therefore, prompting emerges as a fundamental skill for maximising the efficiency of these tools in the workplace, introducing a *new, iterative way of working*.

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3 *"It's another way to work, more iterative. It helps a lot with getting the creative process*
4 *started."*
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6 Critically, unlike in the past, where interactions with technology were a straightforward process of
7 issuing commands and receiving instant results, the use of prompting now involves new skills in a
8 cycle of trial and refinement. This back-and-forth exchange between the user and gen-AI productive
9 tools requires continuous adjustments to achieve optimal outputs (Ronanki et al., 2024). This change
10 in working practices leverages both formal and informal learning pathways. Formally, these tools
11 encourage the acquisition of technical skills in prompt engineering, guiding employees in formulating
12 effective prompts and queries, and evaluating AI-based outputs. With regard to informal learning,
13 employees are encouraged to engage with Copilot's responses as a basis for their own insights,
14 expanding on these initial suggestions through trial and exploration. This iterative back-and-forth
15 aligns well with the principles of informal learning, where knowledge is deepened through hands-on
16 experience, independent inquiry, and problem-solving in real-time situations (Karhapää et al., 2024;
17 Park & Lee, 2018; Tynjälä, 2008).
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27 *"The definition of the prompt - this will become easier as I practice, but it's still*
28 *demanding at the moment."*
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30 *"I do not find the use of Copilot mentally demanding, but if anything is annoying/time-*
31 *consuming/challenging, it is the creation of the right prompts to get a trustworthy result*
32 *for the things you ask."*
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35 In the realm of *knowledge exchange*, respondents agree that Copilot offers support by making
36 previously siloed or hard-to-reach information by providing summaries and facilitating data
37 connections. For instance, employees are using Copilot to search for, and summarise information
38 stored, in shared platforms like SharePoint or Teams, which enhances knowledge transfer and can
39 support better team alignment on project goals and updates. Moreover, by automating the
40 transcription and summarisation of meetings, Copilot facilitates real-time knowledge sharing,
41 reducing barriers to information access and fostering organisational *explicit knowledge* (Nonaka &
42 von Krogh, 2009). In so doing, these productivity applications can support capturing and storing
43 valuable insights, discussions, and strategic decisions that might otherwise be lost or overlooked
44 (Sanzogni et al., 2017).
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52 *"When we don't need to spend so much time on making minutes and taking actions, it*
53 *will be done more often and therefore support follow-through and efficiency in*
54 *meetings."*
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56 This capability can sustain organisational memory by providing both current and future employees
57 with structured records of past discussions and decisions, which can further enhance workplace
58 learning through continuous access to resources for reference and reflection. In doing so, it
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transforms learning and knowledge exchange within the workplace, enriching both formal and informal learning experiences and facilitating broader, more collaborative access to shared knowledge.

4.2 Considerations in meaningful work

"I like to use Copilot in particular also for learning new things. I can easily ask the Copilot to explain things in detail to me and create examples so that I better understand a new topic/concept."

Respondents generally viewed Microsoft 365 Copilot as a system that frees them from lower-value tasks, allowing them to redirect their efforts toward more complex and higher-value tasks that require human creativity, critical thinking, and problem-solving skills, thus allowing a focus on more strategic and cognitively enriching responsibilities. This shift aligns well with the concept of meaningful work, as it enables employees to engage in tasks that they find more purposeful and fulfilling, thereby enhancing job satisfaction and motivation (Awwad et al., 2023). In altering the nature of their tasks and shaping how users apply their skills, Copilot seems to allow employees to contribute in ways that feel both impactful and consistent with their professional growth.

"It enables me to be more productive and can help 'kick start' tasks that would previously have taken a long time to bring to life."

Respondents appreciate that Copilot supports their learning by offering detailed explanations and initial suggestions, which can act as valuable starting points for deeper exploration of new topics. This capability appears especially beneficial for skill development, as employees commented that Copilot helps grasp fundamental concepts more quickly, making complex topics more approachable. Crucially, while Copilot facilitates this initial phase of learning, it does not replace the need for human judgement and intervention in more advanced or nuanced areas. This balance is key: employees can rely on Copilot to handle foundational information yet retain autonomy and creative control over tasks requiring complex problem-solving or tailored approaches. To this end, gen-AI productivity tools can support employees' formal learning processes, acting as a structured, on-demand resource that accelerates the acquisition of essential knowledge—like a *digital tutor*, offering initial guidance that aligns with traditional learning pathways while fostering skill development in a targeted, task-oriented context.

Finally, Copilot seems to reinforce employees' sense of competence and professional identity by enabling them to achieve outcomes more quickly and accurately. Respondents indeed perceive that it boosts their confidence in completing tasks and meeting goals, suggesting that Copilot enhances both performance and professional pride. This practical support adds to a heightened sense of task significance, as employees feel more effective in their roles and better positioned to contribute

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3 meaningfully to their teams and organisational objectives. For instance, several responses
4 highlighted how Copilot's capabilities in summarising complex data or automating documentation
5 allow employees to work with greater impact, reinforcing the purpose and value of their
6 contributions.
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10 *"It makes me more confident about what I am doing, an extra layer of confidence that*
11 *what I turn in is correct."*
12

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14 *"Copilot assists me in what I'm less good at and I like doing less. But it is always a*
15 *collaboration. Copilot does not work (yet) without the human-being behind."*
16

17 However, some respondents caution that the presence of Copilot could potentially lead to deskilling
18 or a reduction in traditional task autonomy. While the tool is effective in aiding decision-making and
19 managing data, there is concern that users may become overly reliant on its suggestions, potentially
20 limiting their independence and diminishing the demand for certain skill sets. One employee, for
21 instance, voiced apprehension that by frequently leaning on Copilot's outputs, they might lose the
22 confidence or habitual expertise required to perform these tasks without assistance. This reliance
23 could gradually erode essential skills, as the tool's efficiency in handling routine tasks may
24 discourage employees from fully engaging in manual processes or critical thinking steps that were
25 once standard. Furthermore, by automating decisions or routine data handling, Copilot could
26 inadvertently shift responsibility away from users, reducing their engagement in the decision-making
27 process. This, in turn, may impact long-term skill retention, as employees are no longer regularly
28 practicing or refining their abilities, potentially resulting in a workforce with diminished capabilities
29 in certain foundational areas. These mixed responses underscore the importance of balancing AI-
30 based support with opportunities for meaningful engagement and personal growth within the
31 workplace.
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4.3 **Considerations of organisational culture**

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44 *"I feel that [the company] is taking this seriously"*
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46 The responses indicate a level of trust in the organisation's ethical standards and in its leadership to
47 manage the ethical implications of AI-based applications' adoption. Some employees expressed
48 confidence in the organisation's commitment to addressing ethical implications and implementing
49 guidelines around Copilot. Indeed, they expect ongoing transparency and active involvement in
50 understanding AI's, including any potential biases or unintended consequences of its deployment.
51 However, respondents also highlighted the need for clear guidelines on what data is safe to input
52 and what guardrails are in place to mitigate risks. This points to a desire for the organisation to
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establish and communicate policies on responsible Copilot usage, which would reinforce a culture of accountability and reassure employees about potential risks.

"I would appreciate clearer direction on what information is not okay to put in Copilot. At the moment I use Copilot less than I perhaps could due to not knowing what information is OK/not OKAY to insert. Hence, going with the 'rather safe than sorry' approach only inserting information not considered sensitive in any way."

Additionally, employees perceive the organisation's stance on AI adoption as progressive and aligned with a forward-thinking, learning-oriented culture. This openness to technology is reflected in the ease with which Microsoft 365 Copilot has been introduced, positioning it as a beneficial tool for enhancing both individual skills and overall team performance.

However, the effectiveness of Copilot's integration is closely tied to the support systems for learning and development within the company. Some employees report that structured resources, such as training sessions, dedicated help desks, and access to documentation, can leverage the quality of interaction with the tool. These resources could make the learning curve more manageable and sustain a smoother transition to AI-supported workflows, contributing to a culture that values and invests in employee development. In this regard, employees seem to agree that the company actively encourages them to take ownership of their learning journeys.

"The roles going forward will be different than today and that is why I do believe that continuous learning is vital for the company."

On the other hand, the rapid need for technical skills is influencing human resource management's strategic decisions, including hiring experts to support and accelerate the digitalisation journey. This has introduced a sense of uncertainty, reflecting the challenges inherent in this transitional period.

"Generative AI will redesign our way of working and necessary skills. I think we all somewhat understand that there is no way out of AI, but it is not clear yet how this will affect us: in one way, the impression is that the tools produced by the many initiatives are not yet reliable enough to make a difference, but we are also wondering if these tools will replace us sooner than we think. Opportunities are as wide as our imagination, though we have not yet seen guidelines or the objectives for gen-AI adoption: it's then easy to fear job loss, especially for those not so young or technically savvy".

4.4 Considerations of organisational socialisation

"It is important to keep teamwork for important decision-making process, as well as organization and team meetings or events to maintain that sense of belonging to [the company], and commitment to [the company]'s purpose and strategy."

The impact of Microsoft 365 Copilot on workplace learning and knowledge exchange within collaborative contexts reveals a spectrum of views on how it influences team dynamics, communication patterns, and the frequency and quality of direct interpersonal interactions.

Responses indicate differing perspectives on whether Microsoft 365 Copilot supports or hinders employees' integration, connection, and shared understanding within their teams.

Many respondents note that Copilot can facilitate collaboration by handling routine tasks like meeting preparation and summarisation, enabling team members to concentrate on strategic discussions and knowledge-sharing. Critically, as the burden of these administrative tasks is reduced, Copilot allows for more meaningful, high-level interactions within teams. Additionally, Copilot's support in managing routine responsibilities fosters a sense of mutual appreciation among colleagues, as team members are no longer repeatedly called upon to assist with minor tasks. This shift can contribute to a more respectful and productive work environment, where social interactions feel purposeful and relevant. Furthermore, this could indirectly benefit new employees, as experienced colleagues may have more time to focus on mentoring and collaborative activities, fostering an environment where organisational values are more openly shared. In this regard, gen-AI productivity tools could support organisational socialisation by reinforcing shared practices and enhancing cohesion among colleagues.

"I think team collaboration and social interactions will not be reduced. Using Copilot does not reduce teamwork or collaboration; it enhances them by allowing for more strategic interactions with the team and avoiding bothering colleagues with operational tasks."

Aligned with these perspectives, several respondents emphasised that, despite the introduction of Copilot, human collaboration remains essential. They noted that these tools cannot replace the expertise, creativity, and nuanced interactions that emerge from direct human discussions, particularly in decision-making and problem-solving—processes that are critical in a dynamic environment like the one in which they work. This reliance on meaningful human interaction for complex problem-solving reinforces the importance of interpersonal connections and informal learning in developing a cohesive environment, where social bonds and experiential knowledge play a central role.

"In our department, the Copilot cannot replace human expertise. It is useful to solve the more mundane problems, so you have to bother your colleagues less with simple things. But the meaningful discussions still are done via human interactions."

"Social and people interaction and team collaboration remain a huge pillar in my work at [the company]. I couldn't imagine me working alone with only Copilot."

On the other hand, some respondents have raised concerns that Microsoft 365 Copilot may reduce face-to-face collaboration and lead to more individualised workflows, potentially impacting how employees socialise, learn from each other informally, and experience a sense of belonging within

the organisation. There is a perceived risk that over-reliance on AI for decision-making, without colleague input, could pose a challenge to collaborative processes.

Additionally, respondents worry that as gen-AI-based applications advance in handling more complex tasks, they may reduce the necessity for human interaction and collaboration, potentially weakening team bonds and interpersonal communication. Respondents reflect that this shift in work dynamics, accelerated by COVID-19, has significantly reduced opportunities for direct, in-person interactions (Agarwal et al., 2024). Notably, within the studied organisation, approximately 36% of respondents now work remotely more than half of their working time. They observe that maintaining strong social connections with colleagues has become more challenging, marking a distinct change from pre-pandemic organisational norms. This shift could influence how knowledge is shared and how team cohesion is maintained in the future. Thus, the use of gen-AI productivity tools may impact informal socialisation, as they could replace certain aspects of human collaborative tasks, particularly for straightforward information exchanges.

“As long as the questions are issues require [the company] specific knowledge/ experience I still reply on colleagues, but for more general knowledge I turn to the Copilot - also because it's always "available" while colleague may be absent or in meetings.”

5. Implications for research and practice

In the face of complex, future-focused challenges, organisations have an ethical responsibility to ensure that work remains meaningful and fosters workplace learning (Lokhtina & Faller, 2024; Lysova et al., 2019). With organisations evolving amid technological transformation in automation, AI, and other technological and social shifts, the convergence of meaningful work, ethics, and workplace learning underscores the need to build environments that provide employees with purpose and opportunities for both personal and professional growth (Gordon & Gunkel, 2024; Lysova et al., 2019; Tommasi et al., 2024).

Workplace learning today signifies a more fluid and integrated approach that blends formal, informal, and incidental learning (Park & Lee, 2018). It thrives on the intersection of individual agency, social collaboration, and organisational strategy, driven by the need for adaptability and continuous professional development (Dwivedi et al., 2020; Voogt et al., 2015). Learning outcomes are no longer confined to measurable knowledge gains but extend to enhanced social capital, innovation, and the creation of new practices (Totterdill et al., 2012). This evolution reflects the growing complexity of work environments and the necessity for learning that is not only context-specific but also transformative for individuals and organisations alike (Islind & Vallo Hult, 2024).

Within this context, and through the theoretical lenses of the sociotechnical capital framework, this study has shown the extent to which a novel generative AI-based productivity technology, such as Microsoft 365 Copilot, integrated to support employees' work, has served not only as facilitator of task efficiency but also as enabler of individual and collective learning (Brătucu et al., 2024; Chowdhury et al., 2022). From an individual perspective, the sociotechnical capital framework suggests that skill development is the process and outcome by which users prompt and effectively interact with Copilot. Thus, the use of Copilot transforms from mere task support to an active component of learning, enabling employees to leverage this technology for professional development and adapt more flexibly to new organisational demands (Li & Yeo, 2024). From an organisational perspective, sociotechnical capital highlights how organisations can leverage a learning framework where AI and human resources can form, in the future, a hybrid (symbiotic) teamwork model, driving the creation of adaptive, knowledge-rich and knowledge-sharing environments (Li & Yeo, 2024; Makarius et al., 2020). In a sociotechnical system, such shared resources are instrumental in ensuring continuity and efficiency across functions while promoting a culture of collaborative learning.

The integration of gen-AI productivity tools like Microsoft 365 Copilot into workplace learning has broader implications for public policy, particularly in shaping labour regulations, skills development frameworks, and educational policies (Holmes et al., 2022). The results also resonate strongly within the field of education, particularly in the design and delivery of teaching practices aimed at preparing future cognitive workers (Borenstein & Howard, 2021). Policymakers must consider how AI-driven workplace technology redefines job roles, skill requirements, and learning opportunities. Moreover, the ethical dimensions associated with AI in workplace learning, such as transparency, accountability, and data privacy, require robust regulatory frameworks (Floridi & Cows, 2019). Public policy must address these concerns to foster trust in AI applications while ensuring equity in access to advanced tools (Winfield & Jirotko, 2018).

Future research should explore specific mechanisms through which AI tools facilitate informal and incidental learning, particularly in diverse cultural and organisational contexts. Such research would advance understanding of how AI tools can extend workplace learning beyond structured learning opportunities, and enhance employees' ability to adapt and grow. By understanding employees' perceptions of AI's role in workplace learning, organisations can design targeted training programmes that enhance both individual skill development and collaborative knowledge sharing. Additionally, fostering a supportive organisational culture that values AI as a complementary resource can improve employee engagement, reduce resistance to new technologies, and encourage a growth-oriented mindset.

As AI continues to improve, the dynamics of AI-human interaction will evolve, requiring understanding of these evolving paradigms and adaptability at the individual, team, and organisational levels. Critically, investigating how employees adapt to and collaborate with AI-based technologies as digital colleagues can shed light on the co-evolution of human and AI roles in the workplace (Glikson & Woolley, 2020). This includes examining the balance between reliance on AI tools and the maintenance of critical human skills (Klingbeil et al., 2024). Finally, integration of AI-based applications reshapes organisational socialisation, influencing team building, collaborative learning, and how employees develop shared understandings and connections (Bailey et al., 2019; Chowdhury et al., 2022). This trend suggests that AI-powered tools could both challenge and enhance the social fabric of organisations, potentially fostering new forms of collaborative knowledge exchange (Lokhtina & Faller, 2024; Selenko et al., 2022).

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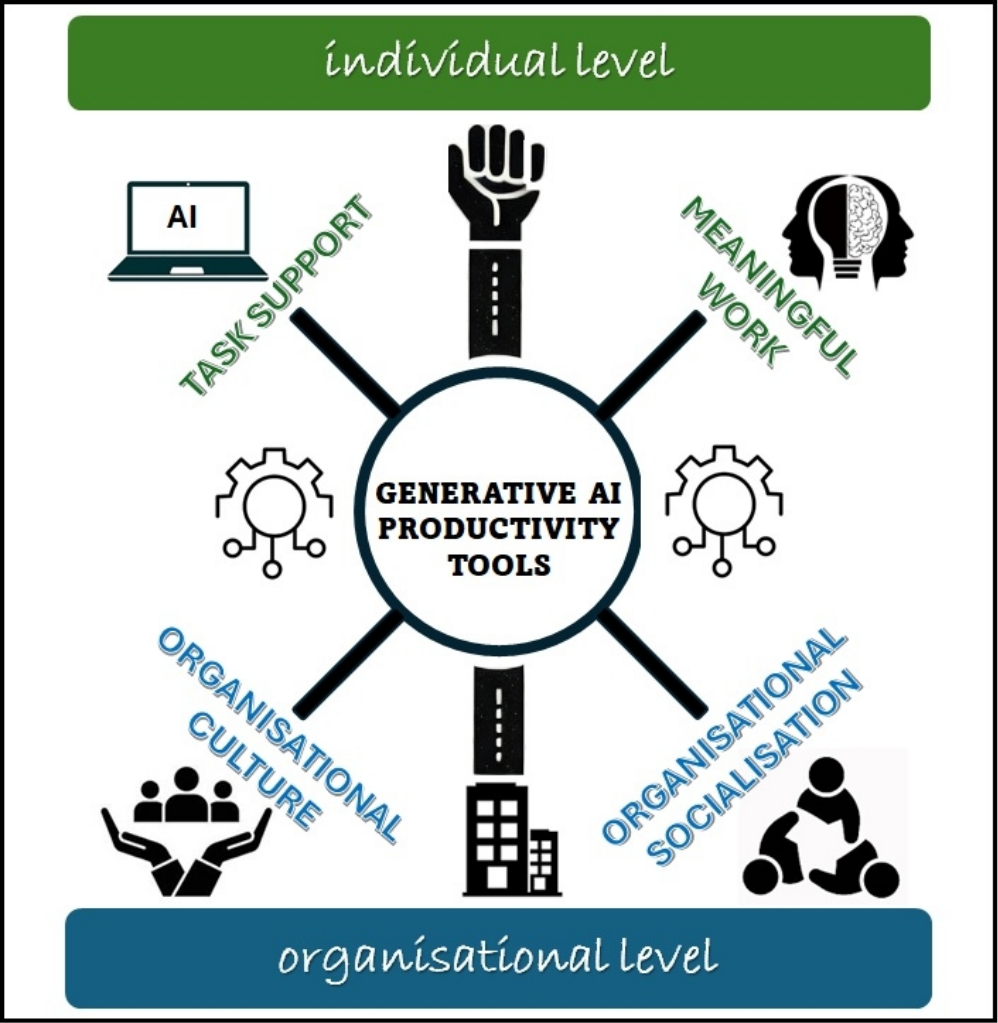
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Can Generative Artificial Intelligence Productivity Tools Support Workplace Learning? A Qualitative Study on Employee Perceptions in a Multinational Corporation

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